



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Charis Classical Academy
School Website: <https://charisclassical.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS: **MEMBER** SCL: **MEMBER**

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Charis Classical Academy Madison (Charis Classical Academy (Madison, WI, 53705)) presents a robust classical, Christian, university-model approach rooted in the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), an emphasis on the Great Books, and a clear emphasis on formation of character through a gospel-centered framework. Public materials consistently frame education as formation of virtue and wisdom within a theologically grounded worldview, with explicit statements about Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as transcendent ideals and about partnership with families in the educational task. The school foregrounds serious classical content (Great Books, Latin, classical languages, history through the curriculum, and a staged progression in Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric) and a pedagogy that blends contemplative/purposive study (Joyful Discovery, living books, nature study) with Socratic discussion, debates, and rhetoric in the upper grades. Public materials also emphasize the role of parents as co-educators and a collaborative, family-centered model (home/school partnership, satellite classroom concepts, and weekly/seasonal arts offerings). Overall, Charis Classical Academy Madison meets the core indicators of classical education across six rubric categories and is best classified as CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**

Evidence

- The school presents itself as a classical, Christian, K-12 institution. This theological framing appears directly in public-facing materials.
- The Word of God is described as the starting point and final authority, with the explicit goal that students know, love, and serve Christ as King.
- Materials describe Gospel-centered pedagogy and a theology-informed basis for education (gospel-centered worldview and grace-centered framing).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present on public materials: gospel-centered, Word of God, theology, Christian, truth/goodness/beauty emphasis, divine/King imagery, Christ-centered aim. These align with Positive Keyword indicators such as theology, liturgy/worship (sacred frame), virtue formation, and transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty).
- Negative keywords: not evident in core public content (no strong secular relativism, no explicit value-neutral framing observed in the public pages provided).

Why this rating

- Foundational theological integration is explicit (gospel-centered, Word of God as authority) and tightly coupled with the classical frame (Christian humanist formation, virtue formation implied). This meets the “Grounded in Theology” and “Transcendental moral realism” signals from the classical rubric, and the public materials foreground a sacred orientation to education.

Citations: the school’s Christian/theological framing appears in the public materials (Charis identified as classical, Christian; Word of God as starting point/final authority).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school emphasizes formation over mere information, with explicit aims of forming character and joy in learning, and seeing a heart for service.
- The mission statement ties education to formation in virtue and wisdom within a gospel-centered frame (the goal to know, love, and serve Christ; formation of the whole child; character development).
- References to Great Books and the Great Conversation, and to the development of the whole person through classical education, are central in curriculum descriptions.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, character, wisdom, beauty (transcendentals), Great Books/Great Conversation, love of learning, moral imagination, soul formation.
- Negative keywords: none of the modern, secular career-focus terms (e.g., workforce readiness, college-placement metrics) appear as primary mission statements in public materials.

Why this rating

- The materials consistently articulate formation as the primary aim, with virtues such as wisdom and beauty foregrounded. This aligns with the Classical rubric’s emphasis on formation, transcendentals, and the teleology of education, and with the Great Conversation and human-excellence aims.

Citations: formation/character/virtue language appears in public materials (formation of the whole child; virtue/wisdom; Great Books).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The curriculum follows the Grammar–Logic–Rhetoric progression and explicitly names the seven liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium) as foundational.
- History is woven through the curriculum; students read and study Great Books; Latin and classical languages are included; living books/historic primary sources are used.
- There is explicit Great Books engagement (The Epic of Gilgamesh, Beowulf, Odyssey; Dante, Homer, Boethius, Augustine, Plato in advanced stages).
- The curriculum includes collaborative, interdisciplinary, and literature-based approaches with a strong emphasis on reading, writing, and classical rhetoric.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Trivium, Quadrivium, Great Books, primary sources, living books, history, Latin, classical languages, narration, memory, chant, and memorization.
- Negative keywords: Not present (no substitution by social-studies-centric history or heavily project-based-only framing observed in the provided materials).

Why this rating

- The curriculum is explicitly classical: Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, living books, classical languages, and a historically anchored history/arts integration. This strongly matches the classical-curriculum indicators.

Citations: grammar/logic/rhetoric progression; Great Books; Latin; history in curriculum; living books.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Pedagogy combines contemplative moments with rigorous study (Joyful Discovery, nature study, living books) and formal, Socratic/inquiry-based methods in upper levels (Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetorical training).
- Lower school practices emphasize memory, singing/chanting, and repetition (Scholé-like elements) in the public materials and in the textual references to classical pedagogy. The site explicitly describes a progression from grammar to logic to rhetoric, with emphasis on memory, recitation, and living books.
- Upper school emphasizes Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric (thesis presentations, etc.).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic, seminar, discussion, recitation, chant, memory work, rhetoric, debate, living books, classical pedagogy, scholé (learning in restful, contemplative fashion), collaborative learning.
- Negative keywords: None of the strong alternative pedagogy signals (purely project-based, non-discursive, or purely experiential learning dominant) appear as the governing approach in the public materials.

Why this rating

- The pedagogy intentionally blends contemplative/restful elements with rigorous, dialectic, and rhetoric-based practices. The presence of Socratic/dialogic practices in upper grades, plus memory/recitation in the lower grades, aligns with the classical pedagogy rubric.

Citations: Socratic/dialogic pedagogy; memory/recitation; living books; Joyful Discovery; collaborative learning.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials emphasize leadership and staff biographies (Headmaster, Director roles, Board, faculty development). There are explicit bios for interim headmaster and other staff, underscoring the display of virtue and professional leadership as part of the school culture.
- The school presents the faculty as living curriculum and a community of mentors with a shared vision (e.g., faculty development, board pages, and staff bios).
- The school highlights a culture of mentorship and virtue via leadership roles, long-tenured staff, and a governance structure (Board and staff pages).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers/mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher/student, mentorship, virtue, character formation, collegial, faculty of friends, professional leadership.
- Negative keywords: none evident in the public materials (no “facilitator on the sidelines” or non-classical jargon).

Why this rating

- The public materials emphasize teachers and leaders as exemplars and living embodiments of the school's mission, aligning with the classical rubric's expectation of virtuous, well-formed faculty and the "portrait of a teacher" concept.

Citations: Headmaster biography and faculty pages; Board/staff sections; language about "living curriculum" and mentorship.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school explicitly positions parents as partners and co-educators, describing a collaborative model between home and school and a structure that integrates families into the learning process.
- The public materials emphasize community engagement, family involvement, and opportunities for parents to engage with the school through tours, admissions, and informational materials.
- There are references to collaborative learning, parent participation in the weekly schedule, and a mission that includes supporting parents in their God-given responsibilities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parental engagement, home-school partnership, open campus, parent formation, family catechesis, parent training, living tradition in the family, parental responsibility, open visits for parents.
- Negative keywords: not evident in the public materials (no "parents as customers only," etc.).

Why this rating

- The content explicitly frames parents as co-educators and active participants in the educational project, which aligns well with the classical rubric's emphasis on partnership with families and continuity of learning between home and school.

Citations: Partner with families; parent formation and engagement terms; open-campus language.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall assessment: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle

- If any category were to move toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, it would be helpful to:
- Further articulate explicit liturgical/communal practices (e.g., morning prayer, chapel liturgy) to strengthen Liturgical and Communal Practices indicators; the current materials emphasize gospel-centered theology but are less explicit about liturgical routines.
- More explicit public articulation of Socratic discourse standards in lower grades and a broader demonstration of student-led inquiry beyond memory and recitation to further strengthen the Pedagogy indicators in some observers' eyes.
- Explicitly connect outcomes to "truth, goodness, beauty" with concrete evidence of student work or assessment criteria that foreground these transcendentals as observable outcomes (though the curriculum already aligns strongly with these ideals).

Citations for needle-movement notes:

- Liturgical/communal practices gap (explicit mention of liturgy in the public materials is limited; see theology-focused statements and gospel-centered framing).

- Pedagogy depth in lower grades could be reinforced with more explicit examples of Socratic practice in K–8 (the public materials show a pathway but more explicit examples would help some readers).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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